

Trust You Don't Have to Extend

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Most tokens don't deserve to exist. I'll say the quiet part first, because everything I'm building depends on being honest about it. There's a simple test and almost nothing passes it: *would people use this if they didn't think the token would go up?* A game you only "play" to farm gold you hate, hoping it appreciates, fails. A protocol nobody would touch without the emissions fails. If the token is the only reason to show up, you didn't build a product — you built a slot machine and printed your own tickets.

I'm not against tokens. I'm against tokens that exist *instead of* a reason to exist.

Why 2021 was a foregone conclusion

The last cycle didn't fail because the ideas were wrong. GameFi, DAOs, on-chain economies — those were right, and they're still right. It failed because of an order of operations that the economics forced.

Building anything real cost tens of millions and years. So you needed VCs. VCs need a return, so you needed a pre-mine and a team allocation to sell them. And the moment there's a pre-mine, the cap table is structurally short the community — every "up only" narrative now exists to give insiders exit liquidity. The product showed up late and mid, so the *token itself* — the node sale, the governance coin — quietly became the real product, and "the platform" became the story you tell to keep the token bid.

Nobody had to be evil for this to happen. Extraction wasn't a betrayal of the plan. **Extraction was the plan**, because it was the only way the funding math closed. The day you took the round, the ending was written.

What actually changed

AI collapsed the cost of building the real thing. That's it. That's the whole unlock, and it's bigger than it sounds.

When a solo dev can build a genuinely good product for almost nothing, you no longer need the VCs. No VCs means no pre-mine, no team allocation, no one structurally short the community. And it means the token can finally arrive *after* the product has real users — it can **follow market**

fit instead of substituting for it. In 2021 that was economically impossible; you had to sell the token first to afford the build. Now you don't. The token gets to be the last thing, not the first.

This is the part people will misread as "go relive 2021." It isn't. It's: the ideas were right and arrived five years before the tooling that lets them be honest. The tooling is here.

What a token is actually for

So then — what *is* a token for? Strip away everything that has an off-chain version. Buybacks? Companies do those. Cashback? Loyalty programs. Governance? Co-ops. Every feature people brag about has a Web2 twin.

What has no twin is the *adjective*: **trustless**. The one thing that cannot be done off crypto rails is a **liquid, permissionless deed over a pool of value that thousands of strangers co-own, that executes by rules no one can override, and that — including from its own creator — cannot be seized**. Pull any single thread and the old world can fake it: equity gives ownership but no liquidity and a custodian; points give liquidity but the company can revoke them. Only crypto gives you all of it at once, with no trusted party.

That's what a token is for. Not value capture — value capture *is* the speculation I'm disowning. The token is the only instrument that lets the *users* hold a liquid, un-seizable share of the value **their own use** creates. Off-chain, that value accrues to whoever holds the keys. On-chain, the users hold the floor. Nothing else does this.

The flywheel, understood correctly

This is where the word "flywheel" gets butchered. People hear flywheel and think buyback. A buyback is a pop — you spend, the chart wicks, the pressure's gone. That's not a flywheel, it's a firework.

The real machine: real usage generates fees, fees flow into a treasury *no human can drain*, and holders govern that treasury into **protocol-owned liquidity and a floor that ratchets up and never leaves**. Usage compounds into ownership. The community can route it to liquidity, to grants that fund more building, to distributions back to the people who showed up — a console, not a button. And because it's trustless, the loop can't be interrupted, front-run, or rugged by the person who started it.

The keystone — and this is the part I have to be ruthless about — is that the floor has to be fed by **use, not by trading the token**. A floor fed by people flipping the coin is just a deed whose value comes from selling more deeds. That's 2021 with extra steps. "A rising floor proportionate to

non-speculative use" only means something if the thing filling the treasury is *people using the product*, not *people speculating on it*.

No hype, on purpose

Hype is the distribution engine of every token, and I'm walking away from it. Not as a pose — as a filter. In a world where AI makes building free, the feed fills with slop and manufactured narrative, and the scarce thing becomes *attention*. The default answer is to hype louder. Mine is the opposite: **earn it on merit, or don't earn it**.

That's a brutal constraint, and it's the point. Refusing to hype is only survivable if the product is so good that not-marketing it beats everyone's marketing. It's the mirror test aimed at go-to-market. And in a sea of screaming, credible refusal-to-hype is itself the signal that cuts through — *if it's true*. The anti-hype is the distribution, but only when there's something real underneath. Which forces honesty all the way down.

The first instance: a lean anti-Gala

Concretely, the first thing I'm building this way is the thing 2021 promised and couldn't deliver: a games platform — but inverted at every joint that doomed the last one.

Lean, because AI makes it lean. Fair-launched, everything, because leanness is what *makes* fair-launch survivable — you can't fair-launch a fifty-million-dollar burn, but you can fair-launch a build that costs almost nothing. No pre-mine, so no one is short the community. Not a tower with a token on top, but a **portfolio of player-owned game-DAOs** — each game's fees flowing to its own un-seizable, holder-governed treasury, each community owning the floor its play creates.

And the studio gets paid *last*, the honest way: by **governance grant**. I propose continued development; the players who use the thing vote to fund it, transparently, from the treasury their usage filled. That is the exact inversion of node-sales-pay-the-team-first. Gala paid itself up front and delivered maybe. Here the builder is funded by the people who already got value, in proportion to the value delivered, from money no one can abscond with. You can't promise the sky and run, because you never hold the sky.

The very end of this

Follow it all the way down and the surprise is what business I'm actually in.

If AI makes building free, then *building* is no longer the moat — everyone can ship anything, and everyone will lie about it. The two scarce things left are **taste** (knowing what deserves to exist) and **trust** (proving you won't extract). And only one of those can be manufactured on-chain. So the real product — under the games, under the launchpad, under the token — is **un-fakeable alignment between the people who build and the people who use what they build**.

That's the thing crypto was always for and never quite admitted. DeFi, GameFi, DAOs — they were all groping for a use for a single primitive: **trust you don't have to extend**. The use was here the whole time. It's this. Let builders and users co-own the upside in a structure where neither can betray the other, so that a stranger can look at the chain *before* they ever buy and verify that the game isn't rigged against them. In a world drowning in cheap creation and cheaper lies, the scarcest, most valuable thing you can offer is a structure that makes lying impossible.

I'm not building a launchpad. I'm not even building a game studio. I'm building the rail where, for the first time, a builder can be honest *and prove it* — and get paid for the proof.

The one thing that's still missing

I'd be doing the exact thing I'm criticizing if I ended on the inspiring note and hid the gap. So here it is, plainly.

The custody is real and provable today — the treasury genuinely can't be drained, not even by me. The grant-funded payroll exists. The fair launch exists. What does *not* exist yet is the keystone: the rail that feeds the treasury from **usage instead of token trading**. Right now the floor is fed by people trading the coin, which is the one thing my own thesis says it can't be. A fair-launched game will have real players doing real things, and that activity has to be what fills the vault — not the speculation the whole pitch is built to escape.

Until that rail exists, I have the most honest *container* in the space wrapped around the same old *fuel*. The entire job — the only thing that turns this from the best version of the manifesto into the real thing — is closing that gap: making **use**, not the trade, the thing that raises the floor.

That's not the part I write a thread about. That's the part I build.